Nefertari Al-Raschid-Arsad

Prof. Nefertari Al-Raschid-Arsad, Ph.D. is a Filipino scholar, educator, and cultural advocate specializing in Philippine Muslim studies, Muslim education policy, and Tausug leadership traditions.

She serves as an Associate Professor at the University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies (UP IIS) in Diliman, where she has built a body of work that sits at the crossroads of classical Islamic knowledge and the lived realities of Muslim communities in the Philippines.

Deeply rooted in the Tausug (or Suluk) community of the Sulu archipelago, she brings both scholarly discipline and cultural authenticity to her research, particularly in her explorations of how Islamic leadership models are understood and practiced at the community level.

Her signature legacy is best captured in one thread running through all her work: education as a tool for empowerment, justice, and genuine cultural flourishing among Filipino Muslims.

She's known for championing the integration of madrasah education into national curricula, for producing nuanced scholarship on Tausug constructs of leadership, and for helping sustain the intellectual legacy of foundational Philippine Islamic scholars like Cesar Adib Majul.

As a quality assurance officer, a project leader, a researcher, and a teacher, she represents a generation of Muslim Filipino academics who insist that Islamic perspectives belong squarely in the national conversation on education, governance, and peacebuilding.

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Background

The full details of Prof. Arsad's early life remain largely private, as is common among academics who center their scholarship rather than personal biography.

What her research and writing reveal, though, is a scholar deeply formed by the Tausug community of the Sulu archipelago.

Her explorations of Tausug constructs of leadership go beyond textual sources. She draws from oral accounts and lived traditions within Tausug communities, which points strongly to personal or familial ties that give her work an authenticity that purely academic distance rarely achieves.

She belongs to a generation of Muslim Filipino intellectuals who came of age navigating two worlds: the rigorous, secular academic tradition of the University of the Philippines, and the rich, faith-grounded culture of the Bangsamoro communities they came from and continue to serve.

That dual formation is visible in everything she does, from the questions she asks in her research to the frameworks she builds for Muslim education policy.

Education

Prof. Arsad completed her undergraduate studies at the very institution she now serves, earning a Bachelor of Arts in Islamic Studies from the University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies.

She pursued advanced graduate studies with a clear and consistent focus: education policy and Islamic thought in the Philippine context.

Her master's-level work included the development of a framework for integrating madrasah education into the basic education curriculum, an early and telling sign of her commitment to practical, bridge-building solutions rather than purely theoretical inquiry.

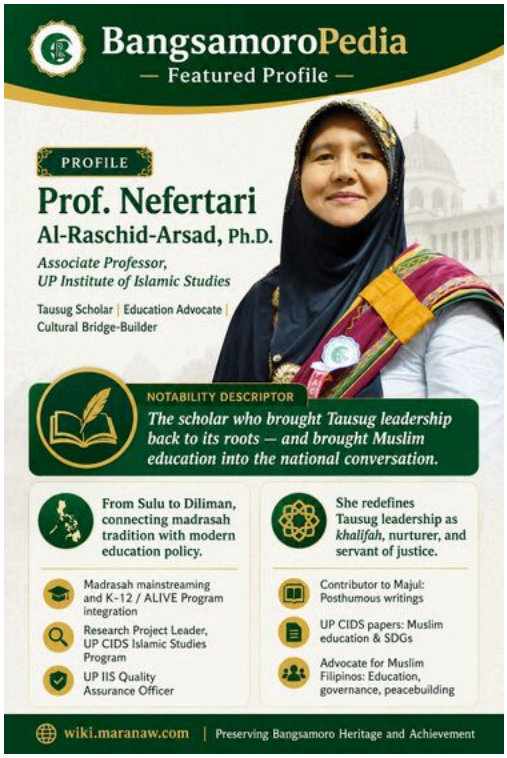
She eventually earned a Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.), deepening her expertise in Muslim educational systems, curriculum development, and the intersections of Islamic values with national educational frameworks.

Her academic formation at UP IIS also immersed her in the intellectual legacy of pioneering Philippine Islamic scholars, an engagement she has carried forward in her professional career.

Career

Prof. Arsad's career has unfolded entirely within the University of the Philippines system, where she has grown from student to faculty member and institutional leader at the UP Institute of Islamic Studies.

Prof. Nefertari Al-Raschid-Arsad, Ph.D.



Born	Philippines
Ethnicity	Tausug (Suluk)
Nationality	Filipino
Occupation	Academic, Researcher, Cultural Advocate
Title	Associate Professor; Quality Assurance Officer
Employer	University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies (UP IIS), Diliman
Field	Islamic Studies, Muslim Education, Educational Policy, Tausug Leadership Studies
Education	Bachelor of Arts in Islamic Studies, University of the Philippines IIS; Master's Degree (Madrasah Integration Framework); Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.)
Known for	Scholarship on Tausug constructs of leadership; madrasah mainstreaming and

	curriculum integration; UP CIDS Islamic Studies Program leadership; contributions to Philippine Islamic studies

As an Associate Professor, she teaches and mentors students in the field of Islamic studies, bringing her research interests in education, leadership, and Muslim community development directly into the classroom.

Beyond teaching, she serves as the Quality Assurance Officer of UP IIS, a role in which she has been recognized for championing QA efforts and completing external reviewer training, contributing to the institutional development of one of the country's most important centers for Islamic scholarship.

She has also taken on a leadership role in the UP Center for Integrative and Development Studies (CIDS) Islamic Studies Program, serving as research coordinator and project leader for initiatives that address real-world challenges in Muslim education and community development.

Her career has taken her to webinars, roundtables, and conferences where she has presented and spoken on topics ranging from classical Islamic curricula to contemporary issues in Muslim education in the Bangsamoro context.

She has organized and participated in academic forums that bring together scholars, policymakers, and community leaders to tackle the practical questions of how Muslim education in the Philippines can be made more inclusive, more effective, and more culturally grounded.

Institutional Contributions

One of Prof. Arsad's most consistent contributions is her work on madrasah mainstreaming. Through UP CIDS discussion papers and related publications, she has helped shape policy conversations around how madrasah schools can be integrated into the Philippines' K-12 framework without sacrificing their religious and cultural integrity.

Her work on the Arabic Language and Islamic Values Education (ALIVE) program reflects the same impulse: finding ways to bring Islamic values education into national curricula in a manner that is both rigorous and contextually appropriate for Muslim Filipino students.

She has contributed introductory essays to collections of the posthumous writings of Cesar Adib Majul, the foremost historian of Philippine Islam. This contribution reflects her role not just as a researcher but as a keeper and transmitter of the intellectual tradition she belongs to.

As Quality Assurance Officer, she has worked to strengthen the institutional foundations of UP IIS, ensuring that academic standards and review processes keep pace with the growing demands placed on the institute.

Her project leadership under UP CIDS has produced discussion papers and policy frameworks that speak directly to government bodies, educators, and community stakeholders working on Muslim education reform.

Scholarship and Research

Prof. Arsad's most distinctive scholarly contribution is her work on **Tausug Constructs of Leadership**, a study that challenges oversimplified and often politically charged representations of Islamic leadership in mainstream Philippine media and discourse.

Rather than framing Islamic leadership through the lens of conflict or extremism, which has become all too common in discussions involving groups like ISIS, she returns to the source: Qur'anic principles, Prophetic example, and local Tausug expressions of what it means to lead well.

In her framework, leaders emerge in figurative and symbolic terms: as nurturers, as stewards (*khalifah*), and as embodiments of moral responsibility toward their communities and toward God.

This scholarship is both a corrective and a contribution. It reorients the conversation away from fear-based narratives and toward the rich, internally coherent traditions of Islamic leadership that Tausug communities have actually lived by.

Her publications also tackle the relationship between madrasah education and the Sustainable Development Goals, arguing that well-integrated Islamic education is not in tension with modern development frameworks but can actively support them.

Across her body of work, a consistent argument emerges: that Muslim Filipino education, when done well, produces global citizens who are grounded in faith, equipped for the modern world, and committed to justice and service.

Cultural Significance

Prof. Arsad represents a generation of Muslim Filipino academics who assert the relevance of Islamic perspectives in national discourse without compromising scholarly rigor.

Her emphasis on *khalifah* as stewardship, on education as a form of worship and social responsibility, and on bridging traditional madrasah systems with modern educational frameworks carries significance that goes well beyond academic publishing.

In a country where Muslim communities have long navigated between marginalization and assertion, her work offers a model of engagement that is constructive, grounded, and unafraid to claim space in national conversations about education, governance, and cultural identity.

She embodies the values she studies: ethical leadership, service to community, knowledge-seeking for the benefit of others, and a balanced integration of sacred and beneficial learning.

Her cultural contribution is also representational. As a Tausug woman scholar at one of the Philippines' most prestigious universities, she demonstrates that Muslim Filipinas can and do occupy positions of intellectual leadership, producing scholarship that matters to both academic and community audiences.

Recognition

Prof. Arsad has been recognized within the University of the Philippines system for her contributions to quality assurance, having completed external reviewer training and been cited for her efforts in championing QA initiatives at UP IIS.

Her scholarship has been published through UP CIDS discussion papers, a platform that gives her research visibility among policymakers, educators, and development practitioners working on Muslim education in the Philippines.

Her contributions to Cesar Adib Majul's posthumous publications mark a form of peer recognition within the field of Philippine Islamic studies, acknowledging her as a scholar capable of contextualizing and introducing the work of a foundational figure in the discipline.

Her active presence in academic conferences, webinars, and roundtables on Muslim education and Bangsamoro development reflects the professional community's recognition of her as a credible and valuable voice in these conversations.

Challenges

Like many scholars working at the intersection of religion, culture, and public policy in the Philippines, Prof. Arsad navigates a landscape shaped by persistent misrepresentations of Islam and Muslim communities in mainstream discourse.

Her scholarship on Tausug constructs of leadership is itself a direct response to this challenge: the need to reclaim and articulate authentic Islamic leadership traditions in a media environment that too often reduces Islamic identity to conflict and extremism.

The work of integrating madrasah education into national curricula also comes with structural challenges, including questions of funding, accreditation, teacher training, and the delicate negotiation of religious content within a secular public education system.

Muslim scholars in the Philippines also face the broader challenge of building and sustaining institutional capacity in a context where Islamic studies programs remain relatively under-resourced compared to other academic fields.

Prof. Arsad's career can be read, in part, as a sustained response to these challenges: doing the patient, painstaking work of building frameworks, producing evidence, and training the next generation of Muslim Filipino scholars.

A Storyteller's Reflection

Encountering Prof. Nefertari Al-Raschid-Arsad through her writings feels like sitting down with a thoughtful mentor who has stories stretching from Sulu to Diliman, always circling back to the same core questions: What does it mean to lead as a Muslim? How do we educate our children so they thrive as both Filipinos and people of faith?

Her approach isn't flashy or self-promotional. It's steady, rooted, and constructive, exactly the kind of voice that builds understanding across divides and across generations.

In the broader tapestry of Philippine Islamic studies, she continues the work of integration and critical engagement that scholars like Cesar Adib Majul began, while staying grounded in the community realities that give that work its purpose and its urgency.

She is, in many ways, a bridge: between the classical and the contemporary, between the madrasah and the university, between the Tausug communities of Sulu and the national conversations happening in Diliman.

See Also

- University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies
- Tausug people
- Madrasah education in the Philippines
- Cesar Adib Majul
- Bangsamoro
- Arabic Language and Islamic Values Education

- UP Center for Integrative and Development Studies

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